

Chapter 46-3

Liang Shi took a deep breath and asked gently, "Teacher Qi, do you have time right now? Could we have a chat?"

Qi Jiao stood up. She was a bit shorter than Liang Shi, wearing light makeup, her long hair tied up with a yellow hair tie¹, wearing a yellow dress with a cream-colored outer jacket.

She was the type who looked completely harmless from her appearance.

When she looked at Liang Shi, she pressed her lips together, then said, "What do you want to talk about?"

Liang Shi glanced at Rainbow. Although this genius girl had just lectured her, Liang Shi still prioritized her "stubborn views" - these matters definitely couldn't be heard by Rainbow.

Liang Shi thought for a moment, "Let's pick a secluded place."

Qi Jiao refused, "Let's just talk here. There shouldn't be anything that others can't hear."

Liang Shi looked around - there weren't many people left anyway.

Just some teachers who were gradually leaving.

Liang Shi called to Rainbow, "Could you go wait in the car for me? I have something I want to discuss with your teacher."

Rainbow looked at her watch, "How long?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She thought about it, "No more than ten minutes."

If Qi Jiao didn't cooperate, it might not even take three minutes.

Liang Shi unlocked the car and watched Rainbow get in, even telling her there was an iPad in the back seat with some science fiction movies downloaded that she could watch freely.

Rainbow carried her backpack and didn't look back, but when she reached the roadside, she looked both ways to check for oncoming vehicles.

When Liang Shi withdrew her gaze, she found that Qi Jiao was still watching Rainbow.

It wasn't until the car door closed and Rainbow made an "OK" gesture from inside the car that she turned around, lightly pressing her lips together, her expression returning to coldness. "Miss Liang, I don't think we have anything to discuss."

"You and Mrs. Qi." Liang Shi said, "The President Qi from Qida Company - you're family, right?"

Qi Jiao frowned and asked back, "What about it?"

Liang Shi exhaled lightly, "I often have a dream where Mrs. Qi appears, and you appear too."

By the time she said this, Qi Jiao's face had already changed.

Her originally rosy cheeks instantly turned pale, "You... what do you mean?"

She immediately shook her head, "I've never seen you before, I don't know you."

Liang Shi smiled slightly, "Really? When we were children, we never met?"

"No!" Qi Jiao answered decisively without a moment's hesitation, "I don't know anything."

Liang Shi saw that her state was unstable and took half a step back, maintaining a safe distance.

"We did meet, didn't we?" Liang Shi spoke gently, trying to let the other person feel her goodwill.

"In that dim little room, your mother didn't just hit you..."

"Sorry, I don't know what you're talking about." Qi Jiao's eyes showed panic, but she quickly interrupted her. "I don't think we need to have this conversation. You won't get the answers you want."

Liang Shi sighed softly, still maintaining her gentle voice while comforting Qi Jiao, "Don't get agitated. This makes me think you're the little friend who experienced those things together with me."

"I'm not, you've got the wrong person." After Qi Jiao finished speaking, she turned to leave, but Liang Shi grabbed her wrist.

"Miss Qi, I heard from Ling Dang that you're still suffering those torments now, is that right?" Liang Shi adopted a roundabout strategy. "I didn't come to reminisce about the past with you. I just heard Ling Dang mention some things, so I wanted to come chat with you."

"Thank you, but I don't need it." Qi Jiao refused.

Then she glanced at her hand, "Please let go of me."

"Don't you want to know how the other little child who was abused is doing now?" Liang Shi asked, "That sister you forced to speak."

"I told you, I don't know you." Qi Jiao said, "I have no memory of the things you're talking about."

"Then why are you so agitated?"

"..."

Qi Jiao suddenly fell silent.

She closed her eyes, "What answer do you really want?"

Liang Shi looked at her, then asked, "Has your mother always been like this?"

Qi Jiao said, "No comment."

"Teacher Qi." Liang Shi smiled gently while loosening her grip on her wrist. "What I want to say is, the way to deal with domestic violence is to become stronger, not to submit passively. That way you'll just keep getting bullied."

Qi Jiao remained silent.

The evening breeze gently swayed the treetops, and vast expanses of fire clouds² appeared on the distant horizon, dyeing half the sky red.

The remaining sunset glow spread everywhere, and slightly yellowing leaves spun as they drifted down from above.

A leaf happened to land on Qi Jiao's shoulder.

Liang Shi reached out and gently brushed it off for her.

"Sister Qi Jiao." Liang Shi used the address from twenty years ago, and even her smile curved exactly the same way as before. "Enduring it won't make things keep getting better."

Qi Jiao suddenly widened her eyes, tears filling them.

"You really don't know anything." Qi Jiao smiled slightly, "So what do you want to do now? Have me help you testify in court about childhood events?"

"No, I just came to verify something." Liang Shi said, "Now I've already gotten the answer I wanted."

Footnotes:

¹ Hair tie (大腸圈): Literally "large intestine ring" - a colloquial term for scrunchies/hair ties because of their resemblance to sausage links.

² Fire clouds (火燒雲): A poetic term for the red/orange clouds that appear during sunset, literally meaning "fire-burning clouds."